



FOR PUBLICATION

DERBYSHIRE COUNTY COUNCIL

REPORT TO CABINET MEMBER FOR HEALTH AND COMMUNITIES

22 January 2024

Report of the Director - Public Health

Strengthen Digital Support in Derbyshire
(Cabinet Member for Health and Communities)

1. Divisions Affected

1.1 County-wide.

2. Key Decision

2.1 This is not a Key Decision.

Purpose

2.2 The Cabinet Member for Health and Communities is asked to approve the award of grants to:

- a) Rural Action Derbyshire (RAD) to coordinate the Digital Support Derbyshire Network (DSDN) for 2 years, subject to satisfactory performance, at a cost of £0.050m per annum and a total value £0.100m
- b) Voluntary, Community & Social Enterprise (VCSE) partners to deliver work that strengthens community based digital inclusion. The Digital Support Derbyshire Network will administer the governance, approval and issuing of small grants to community partners within the network, at a cost of £0.050m per annum for maximum 2 years at a total value of £0.100m.

3. Information and Analysis

- 3.1 There is a strong correlation between digital exclusion, financial exclusion, and social exclusion. Covid-19 led to a widening of this digital divide, as more products and services moved online and became 'digital by default'. Additionally, those facing digital exclusion are more likely to have other challenges that make it difficult for them to access information and engage with online services such as adults with a registered disability or long-term health condition and/or on low incomes.
- 3.2 Increasing opportunities for digital inclusion is essential to reduce health inequalities and helps tackle financial and social exclusion by (1) empowering residents to develop and improve digital skills, ensuring everyone is connected, and (2) embedding digital inclusion in the everyday work of organisations, as well as ensuring that this work is sustainable.
- 3.3 Recognising this, in June 2021, the Public Health Investment Panel supported the proposed investment from the public health reserve to develop a public health approach to address emerging digital inclusion issues.
- 3.4 Following a robust procurement exercise, Citizens Online were awarded the contract and commenced work in April 2022. Citizens Online collaborated with 655 stakeholders to understand digital exclusion risk factors in Derbyshire and produced a draft public health digital inclusion strategy with a set of recommendations.
- 3.5 Whilst the strategy was being developed, VCSE partners across Derbyshire were also forming the DSDN. Work has been coordinated and funded by RAD, utilising one-off short-term funding from NHS Charities Together to deliver community based digital services in localities across Derbyshire.
- 3.6 To maximise resources and reduce duplication, Citizens Online and the DSDN collaborated extensively to inform the emerging strategy and drive the agenda forward. A significant mapping exercise to identify existing digital inclusion provision in Derbyshire contributed towards shaping our direction of travel. The website currently lists 108 digital support offers across the county, which continues to increase (quarterly) due to the work of the network.
- 3.7 Other notable achievements of the DSDN include:
 - Over 250 network members.

- The development of a Digital Pantries pilot into 5 DCC supported Community Food Pantries. This integrates basic digital training and support into food pantry settings. 2 further digital pantries are starting January 2024.
- 5 network events delivered on topics such as digital health apps.
- Planned for Jan 2024 – expansion of PC Refurb work from the High Peak locality to cover the whole DSDN area.
- Planned for Jan 2024 – Digital Awareness Raising Training for organisations across Derbyshire.

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3.8 On 27 November 2023, the Cabinet Member for Health and Communities was briefed on the Derbyshire Public Health Digital Inclusion Strategy (2023- 2026) and supported implementation being undertaken by officers within the public health team.

3.9 The strategy outlines how Public Health can work with internal County Council departments and other external community stakeholders to champion and shape the future of digital inclusion work across Derbyshire. The three key priority areas are summarised below:

- Residents are empowered to develop and improve digital skills.
- Everyone is connected.
- Digital Inclusion is embedded into organisations and provision is sustainable.

3.10 To kickstart delivery against these priorities this report outlines proposals to strengthen collaboration with VCSE partners, who are placed to work with local communities to improve digital skills. However funding for coordination of DSDN is coming to an end, and sustainability of the network is now at risk. Whilst it is recognised that there are over 100 digital support offers in Derbyshire currently, without strategic coordination of the Derbyshire offer there is a risk of duplication across the system. Draft findings from an evaluation conducted by Sheffield University (2023) into DSDN has also concluded that networks “need time to develop, identify synergies and expand their reach”.

3.11 Strengthening future community based digital inclusion is a key enabler for public health and offers the opportunity to contribute towards the following areas of work:

- Addressing the wider determinants of health, e.g., supporting people to gain employment via online applications or by contributing towards income maximisation through online savings.